

reason why apps ask for certain permissions before installation. Google incorporated this feature in good faith but it's often ignored by users. As a security best practice, users should always go through the permissions an app requires, and they should refrain from installing apps that look suspicious. For example, a game should not ask permission to read user's contacts.

Application locks: If a device is changing hands, users might want to protect their personal data (SMS, pictures, WhatsApp messages, emails, etc) from prying eyes. An application lock is an answer to this problem. By installing apps like AppLock, Smart App Protector, etc, users can put a password on apps that store personal data. Once implemented, a password-protected app will ask the user for a PIN before launching.

Transaction password for Play Store: Users who want to purchase apps, books, songs, movies, etc, from Play Store are required to store their payment information (credit/debit card details) in their Google Account. Once the information is stored, users can perform transactions in Play Store with just one click. While this can be very convenient to use, it poses the risk of credit card information being used for malicious purposes like unauthorised purchases. To prevent this, Play Store provides a feature wherein users can set a transaction password. This can be found in Play Store under *Settings > User Controls > Password*.

Rooting device: Android ROMs, shipped with devices, do not provide root access, by default. While many users won't require root privileges on their device, advanced users

and developers often like to experiment with their device. If users wish to opt for rooting their device they should only use trusted ROMs (for example, Cyanogenmod). Untrusted ROMs may have malicious apps running in the background.

Besides the above list, Google and Android developers are working hard to enhance the overall security of Android. In Android 4.3 (released on July 24, 2013), Google has extended Android's 'Verify App' feature to verify even the side loaded apps. In addition, Google is all set to launch Android Device Manager for Android 2.2 and above. Android Device Manager can be viewed as a personal Mobile Device Management solution for Android users. With this app, users can locate their device on a map in real-time. It will also allow them to ring a silenced phone at maximum volume.

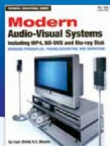
Google is also working on de-constructing the Android environment. This means that most of the apps that shipped as part of stock Android ROM are now being published by Google as standalone apps (Google Keyboard is the latest addition to this). Who knows, Google may decide to add some security apps (for example, encryption) to this bucket. Let's keep our fingers crossed! 

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